The Yellow Wallpaper

By Paul Kuritz

(adapted from the short story by Charlotte Perkins Gilman)

[Light finds her in her room, JOHN has just exited. Bed in upper right corner, chair and writing desk upper left, exit upper left. SHE notices the audience and begins to talk about her house.]

SHE: Ancestral halls...A colonial mansion, An hereditary estate. *[Aside.]* I would say a haunted house, and reach the height of romantic felicity-but that would be asking too much of fate! Still! There is something queer about it. Else, why should it be let so cheaply? And why have stood so long "untenanted"? John laughs at me. But one expects that in marriage. John is practical in the extreme. He has no patience with faith [lifting her Bible], an intense horror of superstition, and he scoffs openly at any talk of things not to be felt and seen and put down in figures. John is a physician. And perhaps, perhaps that is one reason I do not "get well" faster. You see: He does not believe I am sick! So what can I do? If a physician of high standing, and one's own husband, assures friends and relatives that there is really nothing the matter with me but "temporary nervous depression-a slight hysterical tendency." What can I do?

INTRODUCTION

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SHE: *[Looking at photo in a frame on wall by bed.]* My brother is also a physician. Also of high standing. And he says the same thing. *[Picking up pill containers and lines them up on the floor.]* So I take phosphates. Phosphites, Tonics, and journeys,

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and air, and exercise, and am absolutely forbidden to "work" until I am well again. Personally, I disagree with their ideas. Personally, I believe that work, excitement and change, would do me good. But what can I do? *[Picking up and looking through papers, laying them one by one behind the row of pill and tonic containers.]* I did write for a while in spite of them. But it exhausts. Having to be so sly about it. I sometimes fancy that in my condition if I had less opposition and more society and stimulus-but John says

JOHN: The very worst thing you can do is to think about your condition.

SHE: I get angry with John sometimes. I never used to be so sensitive. I think it is due to this nervous condition. But John says

JOHN: If you feel so, you will neglect proper self-control.

SHE: So I control myself. And that makes me very tired. I don't like this room a bit. I wanted one downstairs that opened on the piazza and had roses all over the window, and such pretty old-fashioned chintz hangings! But John would not hear of it.

JOHN: There was only one window and not room for two beds, and no near room for me if I took another.

SHE: He is very careful and loving. He hardly lets me stir without special direction. I have a schedule prescription for each hour in the day. He takes care of me. So I feel ungrateful not to value it more.

JOHN: We came here solely on your account. You are to have perfect rest and all the air you can get. Your exercise depends on your strength, my dear. And your food somewhat on your appetite. But air you can absorb all the time.

SHE: So we took this-the nursery at the top of the house. It is a big, airy room, the whole floor nearly. It was nursery first and then playroom and gymnasium: the windows are barred for little children, and there are rings and things in the walls. The paint and paper look as if a boys' school had used it. It is stripped off

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in great patches all around the head of my bed, about as far as I can reach, and in a great place on the other side of the room low down. I never saw a worse paper. No wonder the children hated it! I'd hate it myself if I had to live in this room long.

SHE: John is away all day, and even some nights when his cases are serious. I am glad my case is not serious! But these nervous troubles are dreadfully depressing. John does not know how much I suffer. He knows there is no reason to suffer. And that satisfies him. Of course it is only nervousness. But it weighs on me not to do my duty in any way! I meant to be such a help to John-a real rest and comfort. And here I am a burden. Already! Nobody believes what an effort it is to do what little I can: - to dress and entertain, and order things. It is fortunate Mary is so good with the baby. Such a dear baby! And yet I cannot be with him. It makes me too nervous. I suppose John never was nervous. He laughs at me about this wallpaper! At first he meant to repaper the room, but afterwards he said

JOHN: You are letting it get the better of you. Nothing is worse for a nervous patient than to give way to such fancies. After the wallpaper was changed it would be the heavy bedstead, and then the barred windows, and then that gate at the head of the stairs, and so on. You know the place is doing you good. And really, dear, I don't care to renovate the house just for three months.

SHE: He is right about the beds and windows and things. It is an airy and comfortable room. And, of course, I would not want to make him uncomfortable just for a whim. I'm really getting quite fond of this big room. All but this horrid paper.

SHE: If I were only well enough to write a little it would relieve the press of ideas and rest me. But I get pretty tired when I try. It is so discouraging not to have any advice and companionship.

JOHN: When you get really well, we will ask Cousin Henry and Julia down for along visit.

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But I would as soon put fireworks in your pillow-case as to let you have those stimulating people about now.

SHE: I wish I could get well faster. *[Turns back.]* But I must not think about that. This paper looks to me as if it knew what a vicious influence it had! *[Seeing as if for the first time, a major discovery. Perhaps SHE begins to project onto the paper the feelings for JOHN she can't or won't admit.]* There is a recurrent spot where the pattern looks like a broken neck. And two bulbous eyes stare at you upside down. The impertinence of it! And the everlastingness! Up and down and sideways they crawl. And those absurd, unblinking eyes are everywhere. *[Discovers a particular wallpaper seam for the first time and inspects it.]* There is one place where tow breadths don't match. The eyes go all up and down the line, one a little higher than the other. I never saw so much expression in an inanimate thing before. *[Backs away from it toward bed.] [Lies on the bed.]* I used to lie awake as a child and get more entertainment and terror out of blank walls and plain furniture than most children could find in a toy store. I remember what a kindly wink the knobs of our big, old bureau used to have. There *[notices her writing chair]* was one chair that always seemed like a strong friend. I used to feel that if any of the other things looked too fierce I could always hop into that chair and be safe. *[SHE does so.] [Pause.] [SHE notices the paper beside her.]* This wallpaper, as I said before, is torn off in spots. It sticks closer than a brother. *[Noticing the floor for the first time.]* The floor is *scratched [Walking and examining each thing SHE notices empathetically.]* and gouged and splintered. *[Looking at the ceiling.]* The plaster is dug out here and there. *[At her bed.]* And this great heavy bed looks as if it had been through the wars. But I don't mind it a bit-only the paper. *[Noticing the wallpaper, as if discovering something very important about it for the first time.]* This wallpaper has a kind of sub-pattern in a different shade, a

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particularly irritating one. You can only see it in certain lights. *[Gets candle, lights it, and uses it to examine the wallpaper more closely.]* And not clearly then. But in the places where it isn't faded and where the sun is just so I can see a strange, provoking, formless sort of figure. It seems to skulk about behind that silly and conspicuous front design.

SHE: *Fighting back tears]* I cry at nothing. And cry most of the time. Of course I don't when John is here or anybody else. But when I am alone.... And I am alone a good deal just now. John is kept in town very often by "serious cases." And Jennie is good and lets me alone when I want her to. *[Trying to talk herself into believing it to be true.]* I'm getting really fond of the room in spite of the wallpaper. Perhaps because of the wallpaper. It dwells in my mind so! I lie here on this great immovable bed-it is nailed down, I believe-and follow that pattern about by the hour. It is as good as gymnastics. I start at the bottom, down in the corner over there where it has not been touched, and I determine for the thousandth time to follow that pointless pattern to some sort of a conclusion. But, on the other hand, they connect diagonally. And the sprawling outlines run off in great slanting waves of optic horror. The whole thing goes horizontally, too. At least it seems so. It makes me tired to follow it.

SHE: Dear John! He loves me very dearly. He hates to have me sick. I tried to have a real earnest reasonable talk with him the other day: Let me go and visit Cousin Henry and Julia.

JOHN: You aren't able to go. Nor able to stand it after you got there.

SHE: I did not make a very good case for myself. I was crying before I finished. It is getting to be a great effort to think straight. Just this "nervous weakness" I suppose. And dear John gathers me up in his arms. And just lays me on the bed, and sits by me, and reads to me till it tires my head.

JOHN: You are my darling and my comfort and all I have. You must take care of

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yourself. For my sake. And keep well. No one but you can help you out of this. Use your will and self-control. Don't let any silly fancies run away with you.

SHE: There are things in this paper that nobody knows but me. Or ever will. Behind the outside pattern the dim shapes get clearer every day. It is always the same shape, only very numerous. And it is like-a woman, stooping down and creeping about behind that pattern. I don't like it a bit. I wonder... I think... I wish John would take me away from here! It is so hard to talk to John about my case. He is so wise, he loves me so... But I tried it last night. It was moonlight. The moon shines in all around. I hate to see it sometimes, it creeps so slowly. John was asleep and I hated to wake him. So I kept still and watched the moonlight on that undulating wallpaper till I felt creepy. *[Sees the figure shaking the paper for the first time.]* The faint figure behind seems to be shaking the pattern. As if she wants to get out. I got up softly and went to feel and see if the paper did move. And when I came back-John was awake.

JOHN: What is it, little girl? Don't go walking about like that. You'll get cold.

SHE: I really am not gaining here. I want you to take me away.

JOHN: Why, darling, our lease will be up in three weeks. I can't see how to leave before. The repairs are not done at home. I cannot possibly leave town just now. Of course if you were in any danger, I could and would. But you really are better, dear, whether you can see it or not. I am a doctor, dear, and I know. You are gaining flesh and color. Your appetite is better. I feel really much better about you.

SHE: I don't weigh a bit more, nor even as much. My appetite may be better in the evening when you are here, but it is worse in the morning when you are away!

JOHN: Really, dear, you are better!

SHE: Better in body perhaps

[JOHN sits up straight and looks at her with a stern, reproachful look.]

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JOHN: My darling, I beg of you, for my sake and for our child's sake, as well as for your own, never, even for one instant, let that idea enter your mind! There is nothing as dangerous, as fascinating, to a temperament like yours.

SHE: There is one marked peculiarity about this paper. A thing nobody seems to notice but myself. It changes as the light changes. The outside pattern, and the woman behind it, is as plain as can be. I didn't realize for a long time what the thing was that showed behind, that dim sub-pattern. But now I am quite sure. It is a woman. By daylight she is subdued, quiet. It is so puzzling. The fact is *[SHE starts to say it, hesitates, but this time succeeds.]* I am getting a little afraid of John. He seems very queer sometimes.. It must be the paper! I have watched John when he did not know I was looking. I've caught him several times looking at the paper! *[Vows.]* But nobody will find it out but me! *[Lights fade and up.]*

SHE: Life is very much more exciting now than it used to be. You see I have something more to expect, to look forward to, to watch. I really do eat better. And am more quiet than I was. I don't sleep much at night. I watch developments. There is something else about that paper-the smell! I noticed it the moment we came into the room. But with so much air and sun it was not bad. And whether the windows are open or not, the smell is here. It creeps all over the house. It gets into my hair. Such a peculiar odor, too! It is not bad-at first, and very gentle, but quite the subtlest, most enduring odor I ever met. It used to disturb me at first. I thought of burning the house. But now I am used to it. The only thing I can think of that it is like is the color of the paper! A yellow smell. There is a very funny mark on this wall, low down, near the mop-board. A streak that runs round the room. It goes behind every piece of furniture. Except the bed. A long, straight, even smooch. As if it had been rubbed over and over. I wonder how it was done. Who did it. What they did it for. Round and round and round and round and round and round... *[Dizzy, falls into the bed.]*

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SHE: I discovered something. I found out. The front pattern moves! The woman behind shakes it! Sometimes I see many women behind. Sometimes only one. She crawls around fast, and her crawling shakes it all over. She is all the time trying to climb through. But nobody could climb through that pattern-it strangles so.

SHE: I think she leaves in the daytime! I've seen her! I can see her out of every one of my windows! It is the same woman. *[Looking at one window.]* I see her in that long shaded lane, creeping up and down. *[Looking at the other window.]* I see her in those dark grape arbors, creeping all around the garden. *[Back at the first window.]* I see her on that long road under thee trees, creeping along. I don't blame her a bit. I always lock the door when I creep. I don't do it at night. John would suspect something. And John is so queer now. I don't want to irritate him. I wish he would take another room! Besides, I don't want anybody else to get that woman but myself! *[Lights fade and up.]*

SHE: I have found out another funny thing. But I won't tell you this time! I can't trust you with too much. There are only two more days to get this paper off. John is beginning to notice. I don't like the look in his eyes. John knows I don't sleep very well at night. He asks me all sorts of questions, too, and pretends to be very loving and kind. As if I can't see through him! *[Lights fade and up.]*

SHE: Hurrah! This is the last day. John is staying in town overnight, and won't be out until this evening. Last evening, as soon as it was moonlight, that poor thing began to crawl and shake the pattern. I got up and ran to help her. I pulled, she shook. I shook, she pulled. Before morning we had peeled off yards of this paper. *[SHE reveals a bucket of yellow strips of paper.]* And when the sun came that awful pattern began to laugh at me *[Laughs at the paper in the bucket.]* I will finish you to-day! We are going away to-morrow. Jennie was amazed, but I told her merrily that I did it out of pure spite. She laughed and

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said she wouldn't mind doing it herself. *[To the bucket of paper.]* But nobody touches you but me! Not alive, anyway. She tried to get me out of the room. *[Lies down on bed.]* But I said that I believed I would lie down again and sleep all I could; and not to wake me even for dinner. I would call when I woke. Now she's gone. The servants are gone. The things are gone. And there is nothing left. But I must get to work. I have locked the door and thrown the key down into the front path. I don't want to go out, and I don't want anybody to come in. Till John comes. I want to astonish him. *[SHE takes rope with noose from a secret place]* I've got a rope that even Jennie did not find. If this woman does get out, and tries to get away, I can tie her! I am getting angry enough to do something desperate. To jump out of the window would be admirable exercise, but the bars are too strong even to try. Besides I wouldn't do it. Of course not. "People don't do such things!" I don't even like to look out of the windows-there are so many of those creeping women, and they creep so fast. I wonder if they all come out of you as I did? *[Ties end of rope to bed leg and puts noose around her neck.]* But I am securely fastened now. You won't get me out in the road there! I suppose I shall have to get back behind the pattern tonight. That is hard! It is so pleasant to be out in this great room and creep around as I please! I don't want to go outside. *[Sits on floor.]* I won't. *[Hears something we can't hear.]* Why there's John at the door! Calling and pounding! Now he's crying for an axe. It would be a shame to break down that beautiful door! "John dear, the key is down by the front steps." *[Listens again.]* That silenced him for a few moments.

JOHN: Open the door, my darling.

SHE: I can't. The key is down by the front door. *[SHE repeats it again, several times, very gently and slowly.]*

JOHN: What is the matter? For God's sake, what are you doing!

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SHE: I'll just keep on creeping. I've got out at last. In spite of you. And I've pulled off most of the paper. So you can't put me back in!

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